



POLLS, PRAYERS & PROMISES Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi offering prayers with Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot and Sachin Pilot in Mehandipur, Oct. 20; former CM Vasundhara Raje with BJP president J.P. Nadda at a rally in Jaipur, Oct. 4

WHILE CONGRESS IS RATCHETING UP THE CASTE CENSUS DEMAND, BJP IS PUSHING FOR HOLISTIC SOCIAL JUSTICE THAT FULFILS THE ECONOMIC ASPIRATIONS OF THE POOR

But then PM Modi himself is an OBC, hailing from the Modh community of Gujarat. CM Chouhan, too, is an OBC, besides several other leaders in the three states. In Chhattisgarh, it has replaced tribal leader Vishnu Deo Sai with Arun Sao as state chief. Part of the OBC Sahu community, Sao's elevation could inspire the community to return to the BJP since CM Baghel, a Kurmi, has overshadowed Congress partymen like Tamradhwaj Sahu. Sahus are the largest OBC group in Chhattisgarh, accounting for 14 per cent of the population.

THE TRIBAL TOTEM

If OBCs form a majority of the population—and at least 35 per cent—in the poll-bound states, the tribal population is no less significant. Historical data from MP, which has a 21 per cent tribal population, shows that the party that wins more seats reserved for STs forms the government. In 2018, the Congress had won 71 of the 101 ST reserved seats across Chhattisgarh, Rajasthan and MP.

It was no surprise, therefore, that Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi-Vadra chose the tribal district of Mandla in the Mahakoshal region of MP to promise that her party will extend the 6th Schedule of the Constitution that currently has provisions for the administration of tribal areas in Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Mizoram, safeguarding the rights of tribal communities. The Congress also promised to implement the Panchayat Extension to Scheduled Areas (PESA) Act, 1996, in MP, directly attacking the Chouhan government, which has yet to implement the same despite repeated promises. Incidents such as a BJP worker urinating on the face of a tribal in July have also lent Congress ammunition against the BJP.

At the same time, the BJP, which claims credit for electing a tribal woman as the country's president, has always retained a sharp focus on tribal votes in these states. If in September 2021, home minister Amit Shah participated in a function to mark the martyrdom of tribal king Shankar Shah and his son Raghunath Shah in Jabalpur, two months later, PM Modi rechristened Bhopal's Habibganj railway station after the Gond queen Rani Kamalapati. In Chhattisgarh's tribal areas, the BJP is promising to convert 827 forest villages into revenue villages, easing the implementation of development projects there.

LOCAL VS NATIONAL

The sharpest difference in the national parties' approach is in managing the election campaign in these three battleground states. The Congress, wiser from its Himachal and Karnataka outings, has let state units take the lead and set the poll narrative. In contrast, the BJP's campaign strategy is being run and regulated from Delhi. If the Congress has already announced Nath, Gehlot and Baghel as CM candidates for MP, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh, respectively, the BJP has steered clear of doing so. In the process, it has placed a question mark over the future of three stalwarts of the party—Chouhan, Raje and former Chhattisgarh CM Raman Singh.

And though it may not have got rid of the inner squabbling entirely, the Congress has settled the issue of leadership in all states, particularly the two it's ruling in. This, in fact, has been one of the biggest achievements of the one-year-old Kharge presidency. Just as he brokered peace between two warring veterans—Siddaramaiah and D.K. Shivakumar—for the Karnataka assembly polls, he has ensured a truce between Gehlot and Pilot in Rajasthan and Baghel and his deputy T.S. Singh Deo in Chhattisgarh. The central team is also working overtime to ensure the hard-earned peace holds till the polls are over.